In the 1940s and 1950s, Bombay was the intellectual capital of India. It had the country's best social scientists, and its only decent English-language poets and writers. In this literary culture, an Englishman known affectionately as the 'Hawk' set new standards of editing and publishing. The writer Laeeq Futehally, working at that time with the magazine *Quest*, remembers that when they had to choose a printer they settled on the Inland Press, 'for it was also patronised by the Oxford University Press, whose General Manager, R.E. Hawkins—in spite of having only one functioning eye—was known to be the best editor and proofreader in South East (sic) Asia'.

The books published by Hawkins were carefully edited, rigorously proofread, and often beautifully produced. In the works of his favourite authors, words and pictures were exquisitely matched. No books produced in India before or since, equal in this respect, such gems as Verrier Elwin's *The Tribal Art of Middle India* and Salim Ali's *Indian Hill Birds*.

Hawkins retired from the OUP in 1970. Five years later, he was present when the tenth and final volume of the *Handbook of Indian Birds* was released in the presence of the prime minister. Asked to speak, the Hawk read out the following verse:

William Shakespeare's a master of words
And a tusker a leader of herds
But wherever you fare
Over land, sea or air
Salim Ali's the raja of birds

In his last years as general manager, Hawkins was assisted by two gifted young Indians. Girish Karnad was a mathematician by training and a playwright by temperament. Ravi Dayal was a history scholar who had read widely in the social sciences. After seven years in the press, Karnad left to make a career in films. Dayal stayed on, and in 1971, moved to Delhi to start a branch of the OUP there. The city was coming to replace Bombay as the intellectual capital of India. An air of self-confidence was abroad. Scholars in Delhi University and the Jawaharlal Nehru University thought